

The causes of mood swings

During puberty, parts of the brain mature at different rates. The limbic system, the part responsible for emotions and feelings, develops early on. The prefrontal cortex, which regulates a person's response to their emotions, doesn't develop until later, toward the end of puberty. While the prefrontal cortex catches up with the limbic system, teens tend to experience extreme emotions and are generally less able to control their emotional responses, resulting in mood swings.

Mood swings aren't just down to teenage brain development, however. The pressures of puberty—encountering new situations; feeling self-conscious; coping with peer pressure and increased expectations; and worrying about exams, relationships, and the future—all play a major role in teens' changing moods.

PARENT TIPS

Supporting your teen

- If your teen is experiencing extreme emotions, try to identify and support them with the underlying cause or feeling, rather than focusing on their behavior.
- Give them space to relax and let them know you're there for them. Once your teen is calm, talk through any issues together.

